

Disambiguating “Evolution” and “Evolution Feed” Across the Trilogy

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This work derives from and formalizes commitments across the CKS theory trilogy: *The Instinct/Reasoning Separation Outside the Model* (Li, April 2026), *Coordination Outside the Model: A Human-Governed Substrate Pattern for AI Systems* (Li, April 2026), and *Inter-Self Coordination via Shared Substrate / Full Aspect Integration* (Li, April 2026). It does not introduce new axioms. Its sole contribution is to articulate, in operational form, the distinct meanings of the term *evolution* and its compounds as those terms are used across the trilogy, so that downstream work can adopt or argue against each term without ambiguity.

Abstract

The CKS trilogy uses “evolution” and its compounds — “vertical evolution,” “evolution feed,” and “collective evolution” — across Papers 2 and 3 with related but distinct meanings at different architectural scopes. The terms share a family resemblance that creates two significant misreading risks: treating the evolution feed (Paper 3, Claim 4) as a new evolution mechanism rather than as a delivery pathway into Paper 2’s existing mechanisms, and treating collective evolution (Paper 3, Claim 6) as a new governance mechanism rather than as a projected emergent property stated in calibrated-humility register. This note formalizes four distinct evolution-family concepts, establishes the central disambiguation that the evolution feed is a pathway not a mechanism, clarifies that vertical evolution names the same upward-propagation pathway in both papers with expanded input sources in Paper 3, and provides an operational test for applying each term correctly.

1. Why disambiguation is needed

Paper 1 does not use “evolution” as a primary concept. It establishes the governance substrate, conflict-as-first-class-state, and the AI-as-substrate-mediator property — the architectural foundations that Paper 2’s evolution mechanisms operate upon — but it does not address how governance architectures change over time. Evolution enters the trilogy at Paper 2 scope.

Paper 2 introduces three evolution mechanisms operating in productive tension within a single Self: instinct evolution (LLM upgrade), DNA evolution (governance-authorized directed

selection on DNA-layer content), and action-feedback evolution (operational records generating proposals that feed directed selection). Paper 2 also introduces two evolution axes — horizontal (refinement within existing structure) and vertical (structural reorganization through the governance hierarchy). These terms at Paper 2 scope are precise and bounded: they describe intra-Self governance architecture change under unified human governance.

Paper 3 then introduces two additional evolution-family terms — “evolution feed” and “collective evolution” — that operate at Paper 3 scope. Neither term introduces new evolution mechanisms. Yet both compound the existing Paper 2 vocabulary in ways that, without explicit disambiguation, can be misread as introducing fresh mechanisms. An adversary could claim that Paper 3’s four-locus evolution feed is a novel evolution architecture unrelated to Paper 2’s three mechanisms, or that collective evolution names a new governance mechanism independent of the mechanisms Paper 2 establishes. Both readings mischaracterize the architecture. This note forecloses them.

2. The four evolution-family concepts

Four concepts compose the evolution family across the trilogy. Each has a specific scope, a specific paper locus, and a specific architectural role.

Intra-Self evolution (Paper 2, §7): The process by which one Self’s governance architecture changes over time, operating through three mechanisms — instinct evolution, DNA evolution, and action-feedback evolution — in productive tension across all three levels of the Self’s composition (cell, aspect, Self). Scope: one Self. The three mechanisms are the exclusive mechanism-layer content at this concept’s scope.

Vertical evolution (Paper 2, §7.4; extended in Paper 3, §7): One of two axes characterizing how evolution can change a Self, alongside horizontal evolution. Vertical evolution reorganizes governance structure itself: cells split or merge; aspects gain or lose constituent cells; Selves gain or lose aspects. It propagates governance insights upward through the three-tier hierarchy — from cells to aspects to the Self — informing governance decisions at each tier. Because the orchestration substrates defining composition are themselves substrate content humans govern, vertical evolution is a substrate-edit operation available at Paper 2 scope without additional mechanism design. At Paper 3 scope, vertical evolution operates with the same upward-propagation pathway but with FAI-origin records added as an additional input source after they enter the home action layer through the evolution feed.

Evolution feed (Paper 3, Claim 4): The four-locus mechanism by which FAI events deliver outputs to each participating Self’s home Paper 2 evolution machinery at the FAI hand-off boundary. When the shared substrate dissolves at the close of a Full Aspect Integration event, content propagates to each participating Self’s home substrate through governance-configured ingestion at the home perimeter. The four loci are: hand-off at FAI

dissolution; per-mechanism feed structure routing content to the appropriate Paper 2 mechanism; a layer-routing rule specifying that action-layer content routes to action-feedback evolution and DNA-layer content routes to directed selection; and asymmetric ingestion configured per home governance. Scope: inter-Self delivery mechanism feeding intra-Self evolution processes. Instinct evolution remains out of scope — LLM-layer content does not cross the inter-Self perimeter.

Collective evolution (Paper 3, Claim 6, calibrated-humility register): The projected population-scale pattern where accumulated FAI events, operating under Paper 3's configuration-as-substrate-content commitment with recursive applicability, collectively advance governance practices across the network of participating Selves. Scope: population. Register: calibrated-humility projection of an emergent property, not a claim about a mechanism.

3. The central disambiguation: evolution feed is a pathway, not a mechanism

The most consequential disambiguation in this family is between “evolution feed” and “evolution mechanism.” Conflating them mischaracterizes the architecture at its core.

Paper 2's three evolution mechanisms — instinct evolution, DNA evolution, and action-feedback evolution — are the mechanism layer. They define *how* a Self's governance architecture changes. They are located entirely within the home perimeter of a single Self, operating under that Self's unified human governance.

The evolution feed (Paper 3, Claim 4) is not a fourth evolution mechanism alongside these three. It is a delivery pathway — a specification of how FAI-event outputs reach the home perimeter and enter Paper 2's existing mechanisms as inputs. The four loci of the evolution feed articulate what happens at the FAI hand-off boundary: what triggers ingestion, how content is routed to the appropriate mechanism by layer, how asymmetric ingestion is governed, and how conflict annotations from the shared substrate propagate into home substrate as annotated content for home governance to address. None of these loci define a new mechanism of change. Each locates where inter-Self content enters the existing mechanisms of change.

The architectural structure is additive, not parallel: FAI events → evolution feed (delivery pathway at the inter-Self boundary) → Paper 2's existing mechanisms (DNA evolution via directed selection; action-feedback evolution via action layer) → governance architecture change. The mechanisms operate at home perimeter; the feed is what reaches them from outside. Treating the feed as a competing mechanism — or as an additional mechanism operating alongside Paper 2's three — would require the evolution feed to define a new form of governance architecture change, which it does not.

This disambiguation matters for prior-art purposes: any implementation that routes inter-Self coordination outputs into an existing intra-Self governance update process is implementing the evolution feed pattern. It is not implementing a novel evolution architecture.

4. Vertical evolution: same pathway, expanded input sources

Vertical evolution names one architectural property: the upward propagation of governance insights through the three-tier hierarchy within a Self. The pathway is defined once in Paper 2 and remains structurally unchanged in Paper 3. What changes at Paper 3 scope is the set of inputs that can travel through it.

In Paper 2, vertical evolution processes intra-Self operational experience: records from the action layer generated through the Self's own operational history, which proposals then carry upward as potential directed selections at aspect and Self governance tiers.

In Paper 3, vertical evolution retains this function and additionally processes FAI-origin records: after a FAI event's evolution feed delivers outputs to the home action layer through the action-feedback locus, those records become action-layer content within the home Self. From that point, the home Self's existing vertical evolution pathway can propagate them upward through the governance hierarchy exactly as it propagates intra-Self operational records. The pathway is not modified; the source of some records that enter it has expanded to include inter-Self experience.

5. Collective evolution: calibrated-humility projection, not mechanism

Claim 6 of Paper 3 uses "collective evolution" with an explicit calibrated-humility voice anchor appropriate to the trilogy-completion register. The term names a projected emergent property, not a new governance mechanism.

The claim is: when many CKS-governed Selves accumulate FAI events under Paper 3's configuration-as-substrate-content commitment with recursive applicability, the cumulative coordination structure produced is itself an architectural object — substrate content at population register — and the accumulated evolution-feed dynamics across many Selves produce population-scale collective evolution. This is what Paper 2's evolution mechanisms, extended through Paper 3's evolution feed and configuration commitments, project at population scope. The calibrated-humility register is essential: Claim 6 articulates what these preceding commitments compose into when many Selves accumulate many events, not a freshly designed population-level evolution governance system.

Treating collective evolution as a governance mechanism would require identifying a mechanism of population-scale governance change that is independent of, or additive to, Papers 2 and 3's specified mechanisms. No such mechanism is specified. Collective evolution is the name for the aggregate pattern those mechanisms produce at population

scope — a projection, not an architectural addition.

6. Operational test

A reader applies the evolution-family terms correctly if the following hold:

1. When encountering “evolution” without qualification in a Paper 2 context, the reader identifies intra-Self governance architecture change through the three mechanisms operating within one Self’s governance hierarchy.
2. When encountering “evolution feed” in a Paper 3 context, the reader identifies it as the delivery pathway at the FAI hand-off boundary — not as a new mechanism of change — and locates its four loci at the inter-Self-event-to-home-perimeter boundary.
3. When encountering “vertical evolution” in either paper, the reader identifies the same upward-propagation pathway through the three-tier hierarchy, distinguishing between Paper 2’s intra-Self operational sources and Paper 3’s additional FAI-origin sources that enter through the evolution feed before traveling the same pathway.
4. When encountering “collective evolution” in a Paper 3 Claim 6 context, the reader applies the calibrated-humility register: this is a projected emergent property of accumulated FAI events at population scope, not a mechanism.
5. A reader who treats the evolution feed as a fifth evolution mechanism alongside the three Paper 2 mechanisms and vertical evolution is mischaracterizing the architecture; the evolution feed is a pathway to those mechanisms, not among them.

7. Conclusion

The evolution family across the CKS trilogy names four distinct concepts at four distinct scopes. Intra-Self evolution (Paper 2) is the mechanism layer: three processes that change a Self’s governance architecture. Vertical evolution (Paper 2 and Paper 3) is one axis of that mechanism layer: upward propagation through the governance hierarchy, with Paper 3 expanding its input sources without modifying its pathway. The evolution feed (Paper 3, Claim 4) is a delivery pathway at the inter-Self boundary: four loci specifying how FAI-event outputs reach Paper 2’s existing mechanisms. Collective evolution (Paper 3, Claim 6) is a calibrated-humility projection: the emergent population-scale pattern those mechanisms produce when many Selves accumulate many FAI events.

The central disambiguation that subsequent work should preserve: the evolution feed is a pathway, not a mechanism. Confusing the two mislocates where architectural novelty resides in Paper 3 and mischaracterizes the relationship between Paper 2 and Paper 3’s evolution architecture.

Source papers

Li, W. (2026). *The Instinct/Reasoning Separation Outside the Model*. April 2026. ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235.

Li, W. (2026). *Coordination Outside the Model: A Human-Governed Substrate Pattern for AI Systems*. April 2026. ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235.

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